

Emergency escapes

If an animal's life is in danger, adopting an unusual escape technique can make the difference between life and death. Sailfin lizards hurl themselves off branches and run away across rivers and streams. Beetles sometimes pull in their legs and roll downhill. Many other animals go to even greater extremes and abandon parts of their bodies, while a few simply pretend to be dead. These escape tactics are used against predators only as a last resort, but they often work because they have surprise on their side.

Indonesian sailfin lizard



Ink cloud squirts out of funnel beneath octopus's head

Cloud cover

When danger threatens, an octopus can release a jet of water stained black by "ink." The dark cloud distracts or envelops its attacker, while the octopus makes a speedy getaway. Octopus ink is produced in a sac that forms part of the animal's digestive system. The ink contains highly concentrated melanin—the same chemical pigment that many animals have in their skin or fur.

Playing dead

To escape from attack, the Virginia opossum flops over on its side with its eyes and mouth open, looking as if it has suddenly died. This trick looks suicidal, but it works because most predators eat live prey and choose to leave dead animals alone. Once the hunter has lost interest and moved on, the opossum cautiously comes back to life.

